

1438

INCA EMPIRE FORMED

Acceding to the throne of the small kingdom of Cusco in the Peruvian Andes in 1438, Pachacuti Inca Yupanqui embarked upon a campaign of expansion that laid the foundations for the extensive Inca empire. It was Pachacuti who, in the 1450s, built the royal estate at Machu Picchu, which is now the best-known of Inca ruins. By the end of the 15th century, Inca domains stretched from modern-day Ecuador south to Chile.



◀ Inca Emperor Pachacuti, statue near Machu Picchu, Peru

1439

1434

EXPLORER PRINCE

In 1434, Portuguese seaman Gil Eanes passed Cape Bojador, travelling further down the West African coast than any previous European mariner. This was a triumph for Portugal's Prince Henry, known as "the Navigator", who promoted exploratory voyages, initiating Europe's Age of Discovery.



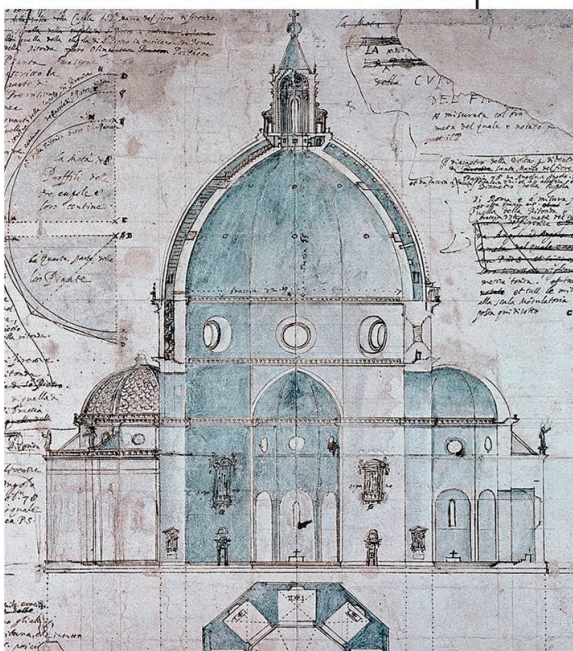
▽ Henry the Navigator

1434 Cosimo de' Medici becomes the effective ruler of Florence

1436

BRUNELLESCHI'S DOME

The residents of Florence began building a magnificent cathedral in 1296, but over a century later it still lacked a dome. In 1418, architect Filippo Brunelleschi won a competition to cap the building. Showing enormous technical ingenuity, he built an octagonal dome 42 m (138 ft) across, without any external buttresses to sustain its weight. Finished in 1436, it was an early achievement of the Italian Renaissance.



▷ Plan of Florence Cathedral from the 16th century



1389-1464

COSIMO DE' MEDICI

Born into a rich banking family, Cosimo used his wealth to dominate the city-state of Florence for 30 years. A patron of artists and scholars, he made his city the hub of the early Renaissance.